

Peripheral whiteness and racial belonging and non-belonging: accounts from Albania

Chelsi West Ohueri

Over my fifteen years of conducting ethnographic research on race and belonging in Albania, many questions have arisen about the applicability of race theory frameworks for understanding marginalisation and the construction of difference in this region. This is especially the case with the topics of whiteness and racism, which are often largely understood as issues of the United States and the ‘West’ broadly defined. While elsewhere I have written about processes of racialisation and the racial logics present in daily life in Albania, the primary goal of this chapter is to historically and ethnographically explore the subjects of whiteness and racial belonging.¹ In doing so, it also illustrates how the ethnographic study of race can shape our historical inquiry into aspects of whiteness and belonging in Central and Eastern Europe that may not have otherwise been considered.

My research draws attention to the complexities of Albania’s proximity to European whiteness. Whether during formal interviews or coffee conversations, many of my interlocutors frustratedly shared sentiments of Albania’s current sociopolitical landscape, often blaming both past and present-day politicians for their inability to change the country, thus preventing Albania from being fully European. It is not uncommon for interlocutors to passionately express anti-Ottoman sentiments, and invoke a distancing from a Communist past and what people consider to be social, economic, and political backwardness. Both the Ottomans and Hoxha, many of my interlocutors assert, have ruined or destroyed Albania (*‘Shqipëria, tani, është e prishur’* ‘Albania is now ruined’). These constructions are particularly acute during discussions of Albania’s prospects for joining the European Union, as people may express their desire for what they frame as *true* European belonging. I argue that these sentiments provide an entry point into the exploration of how European belonging has been constructed historically, and how it is intimately tied to race and whiteness in the contemporary moment.

Albanians have often had to navigate what Isa Blumi refers to as ‘an anxious self-definition as Europeans’.² This anxious self-definition shapes the space of the periphery and what I refer to as peripheral whiteness. This term calls attention to the ways that global racial orders shape paradoxical local landscapes, such that white European racial belonging is not fully conferred to Albanians, and that at the same time, Albanians enact whiteness in relationship to those racialised as ‘black’, particularly Roma and Balkan Egyptians.³ This concept takes into consideration what it means to long for whiteness following Albania’s particular histories of imperialism and state socialism, and contemporary aspirations for European Union membership. It also highlights the angst produced by the longing for what people consider to be full inclusion within Europe, revealing what it means to *feel* and *not feel* white.⁴

My use of the concept of racial belonging is shaped by understandings of racialisation as the processes that give race its meaning, i.e., the ways that race is categorised, understood, and deployed, and belonging that is marked by emotional investment and attachment.⁵ This analytic of racial belonging is further informed by Cedric Robinson’s notion of racial capitalism, which calls attention to the genesis of racism and racialisation *within* Europe, whereby those othered as Eastern/Muslim/Slavic/Roma were the first to be racialised outside of whiteness.⁶ The expansion of Western capitalism, Robinson argues, was itself racialised, and social hierarchisation of so-called racial groups was thought to be natural. Albania, along with the rest of Southeast Europe, has historically been constructed as sociopolitically and economically inferior to Western Europe, particularly as shaped by its Ottoman and Communist histories. I argue that Albania’s position within racial capitalism must be nuanced, as Albania occupies a place of peripheral whiteness in relationship to Western Europe, yet contemporary understandings of racial capitalism produce local racial logics that demarcate the value of humanity as shaped by capitalist structures.⁷ Such structures shape Albanians, Roma, and Egyptians, and their varying proximities to whiteness and blackness. In the case of Albanians, peripheral whiteness speaks to the paradoxes of the space of the margin, where Albanians are both racialised outside of some boundaries of ‘the white world’ and simultaneously have historically performed being ‘white’ for Western audiences, as well as performing being ‘white’ locally against Roma and Egyptians who are racialised as ‘black’. The country’s unique positioning further illustrates how ‘dehumanization seems to be an unavoidable outcome of the processes of capitalist development’.⁸ I employ these frameworks of race to historically and ethnographically examine racial belonging in Albania as shaped by global racial orders, that is by the geographies of racial capitalism, that configure variegated forms of inequality.⁹

In the first section of the chapter, I briefly analyse race in a regional context, including an exploration of racialised constructions of Albanians as perpetual racial outsiders in Europe. In the second section I examine constructions of peripheral whiteness, and how Albanians have been othered as non-white but at the same time have strived to become 'white' through various nation-building projects and promoting claims of authentic European-ness. I interrogate how national narratives serve as a tool for Albanians to craft a white European racial belonging. In the third section I explore more recent local manifestations of whiteness as it pertains to the relationships between Albanians, Roma, and Egyptians, whereby Albanians are racialised as 'white' while Roma and Egyptians are racialised as 'black'.

On race and place in Southeast Europe

Like every region, Europe has its particular racial arrangements, and an exploration of whiteness must be analytically situated within them.¹⁰ We know from Edward Said's theory of orientalism and Maria Todorova's concept of Balkanism about historical divides between East and West, and how understandings of place have shaped forms of belonging, marginalisation, and human hierarchy.¹¹ Todorova in particular notes that while the division was initially spatial, it began 'gradually to acquire different overtones, borrowed and adapted from the belief in evolution and progress flourishing during the Enlightenment'.¹² At the same time, Todorova's analysis of marginalisation fails to address how racialisation and whiteness were organising principles of this peripheralisation.¹³ While common frameworks of the Balkans only emphasise nationality and ethnicity, there is an intertwined relationship between racialisation and Balkan peripheralisation that yields further insight into Europe's racial arrangements.

In their work on post-Soviet racialisations, Nikolay Zakharov and Ian Law note that 'the scholar of race needs to address the question why people employ certain categories (race/blackness/whiteness), under which historical situations these categories are relevant, and under which institutional circumstances ideas of race generate social effects'.¹⁴ As many chapters in this book indicate, Central and Eastern Europe, and in this case Southeast Europe, often occupies a space of racelessness in the scholarly and social imaginary. My ethnographic research has illustrated how such ideas of exceptionalism are additionally present in Albanian discourse.¹⁵ Interlocutors frequently assert that Albania is inherently raceless because of its demographic homogeneity, demonstrated by recent national data shows that between 90 and 95 per cent of the country identifies as ethnically Albanian. Further, many believe that the high levels of religious tolerance in the country demonstrate a universal

acceptance that precludes any racial division. As the famed Albanian poet Vaso Pasha declared during Albania's national awakening, 'Feja e Shqyptarit asht Shqyptaria' ('The religion of Albania is Albanianism').

Such relics from the late nineteenth century have continually emerged and re-emerged in Albania's history and present day, shaping not only ideas about religion but also about tolerance broadly. Many of my interlocutors express that this tolerance is inherently woven into the fabric of social life in Albania, and that as a result race and racism are not relevant to them. Yet I maintain that the language of race and practices of racialisation have been prevalent in Albania for a significant period of time, and everyday racial logics, whether named as such, generate social effects. Recent work by Piro Rexhepi illuminates the forms of global raciality and racial capitalism that have marked and continue to shape Balkan landscapes, even when race is denied or dismissed.¹⁶ When we turn attention away from a singular focus of measuring degrees of racism and notions of racial division, and towards a consideration of processes of racialisation and whiteness, we can see that even these claims to racelessness are actually shaped by racial logics that continually shape who is white, not quite white, and how East Europeans become more or less white over time.¹⁷ As part of globalised racial structures, whiteness carries a myriad of meanings as it manifests across various local settings. While analyses of it in the West do not map neatly onto the Balkans, processes of racial belonging and marginalisation in this region draw attention to the ways that difference and structural advantage are racialised. These developments emphasise whiteness as a particular standpoint through which those who are racialised as white, including those who are peripherally white, view others.¹⁸

Albanians as historically racialised outsiders

Though regional scholarship on the Balkans does not often attend to them, there are particular racial logics that have historically marginalised Albania outside of whiteness. These racial logics have emanated from race theories common to Europe during the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, shaped by practices of both explicit and silent ordering of peoples.¹⁹ The Balkans are Europe's periphery, what Dušan Bjelić characterises as Europe's 'abnormals'.²⁰ I use the idea of peripheral whiteness to analyse how Albanians have been excluded historically and also as an attempt to capture the attachments to white racial belonging. In this way, the case of Albania sheds light on the shifting nature of and fluidity of whiteness and its limits.²¹

Writing about Albania in the early twentieth century, the British anthropologist and writer Edith Durham wrote:

Such backwaters of life exist in many corners of Europe – but most of all in the Near East. For folk in such lands time has almost stood still. The wanderer from the West stands awestruck amongst them, filled with vague memories of the cradle of his race, saying, ‘This did I do some thousands of years ago; thus did I lie in wait for mine enemy; so thought I and so acted I in the beginning of Time.’²²

Statements such as Durham’s demonstrate the widely held anachronistic and scientifically racist notions of this time period. Her ideas further draw attention to the temporal nature of whiteness, highlighting how Western Europeans understood whiteness and Europeaness to symbolise civilisation and arrival. The boundaries of European belonging rendered backward and uncivilised Albanians as racial outsiders, shaping cultural markers that continue to manifest in the contemporary moment in what are still framed as Europe’s backwaters. These constructions of Albania were not limited to Western Europe, as writers from Central Europe articulated similar beliefs. Johann Georg von Hahn was an Austrian imperial-royal consul in Southeast Europe during the early to mid-nineteenth century, and was regarded by Western Europeans as one of the leading experts on Albania. Among his many writings about the nation, his publications included dehumanising depictions of two so-called types of Albanian men with tails, those with goat tails and those with horse’s tails.²³ Such ideas are derived from eighteenth-century thinkers like Carl Linnaeus, who wrote about the so-called satyr species of hairy, tailed men, not thought to be fully human.²⁴

Travel writings by such figures as von Hahn reinforced racist and dehumanising perceptions that lasted well into the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. They also shaped intra-Balkan attitudes and beliefs about Albanians. An example comes from the Serbian Academy of Sciences during the late nineteenth century, in which one member characterised Albanians as ‘bloodthirsty, stunted, animal-like ... modern Troglodytes who slept in trees, to which they were fastened by their tails’.²⁵ Examples such as this one illustrate the Western and Eastern European racial ideas produced by Europe’s social-political structures, whereby Albanians were considered uncivilised, non-human, and not ‘white’. Whiteness in this case replicates a type of temporal logic, such that those deemed backward and undeveloped are external to European whiteness. The timing of these mid- to late nineteenth-century observations provide insight into Albanian nation-building projects. During this time period of the nineteenth century the Ottoman Empire was in decline, and other Balkan countries had either gained independence or were in the process of seeking it. As part of their nation-building efforts, Albanian leaders had to construct a singular national identity, one that was closely aligned with Europe and the West. These experiences of racial outsidership, I argue,

shaped the notion of what it meant to be Albanian, illustrating a particular duality that animates the realm of peripheral whiteness and its complexities: Albanians at this time were striving for white racial belonging while being situated outside of it.

Racial belonging and nation-building projects

The above examples demonstrate the ways that Albanians have occupied a subaltern position external to notions of European racial belonging. I argue that there are historical instances that illustrate how some conceptualisations of Albanian national identity were shaped by this exclusion and also by desires of European white inclusivity. The study of race itself in Albania is complex, and there is little in the historical record that includes the explicit language of 'white' or 'whiteness'. Yet I argue that racial ideologies of whiteness, underpinned by notions of modernity and civility, shaped Albania's early twentieth-century nation-building projects.²⁶ Facets of this racial imaginary are especially salient when examining how Albania was constructed by those nationalist leaders who were located outside of Albania. Albania was the last country to declare independence from the Ottoman Empire, and like other Balkan countries, its national leaders sought to obtain formal statehood recognition from the Great Powers in the early twentieth century. One method that Albanian leaders used to influence the Great Powers was the adoption of the Pelasgian theory within nationalist discourse. In particular for those Albanian nationalists who resided in Western Europe and the United States in the 1910s, the theory that Albanians were direct descendants of the Pelasgians, and therefore, the earliest inhabitants of the Balkan region predating Slavs and Greeks, became a means to affirm the status of Albanians as the 'lawful owners of Albania'.²⁷ This was an attempt to proclaim authentic and original European whiteness, contrasted with an uncivilised and barbaric Ottomanness which they vested in their Turkish imperial rulers. Albanian writers like Konstandin Cekrezi, who resided in the US in the early twentieth century, wrote at length about Albanians' perpetual struggle to protect their land and identity against foreign oppressors.²⁸ I do not draw attention to this Pelasgian theory of descent to enter a debate about its legitimacy, but rather to highlight how such theories were employed by nationalist leaders to fight against expansionism from nearby countries and to assert an Albanian identity that was distinct from the Ottomans, the Greeks, and the Slavs.

The Albanian identity shaped by the latter period of the country's 'Rilindja' ('Rebirth') illuminates facets of the early twentieth-century racial imaginary, in which both Albania and Europe were constructed against Islam. One of

the best illustrations of this lies in the figure of Albania's national hero, Gjergj Kastrioti Skënderbeu, more commonly known as Skanderbeg. The story of Skanderbeg dates back to the fifteenth century, when it is believed that he led a series of battles against the Ottoman Empire.²⁹ Nationalist leaders, particularly those who were Orthodox and from southern Albania, celebrated Skanderbeg as the valiant defender of Christian Europe, the hero who had vigorously fought against Muslim invasion, defending Europe from 'vile Asiatic hordes'.³⁰ These constructions of Skanderbeg as Albania's and Europe's saviour gained significant currency as a means to appeal to the Great Powers during the nationalist period. Writers, both inside and outside the country, produced material trumpeting Skanderbeg's story. Political leaders further employed Skanderbeg's story to cement authority. King Zog I, for example, who would lead Albania in the 1920s and the 1930s both as President and later as King, was heralded as the direct descendant of Skanderbeg. Some even referred to him as Skanderbeg's grandson and the country's saviour who could defend Albania against invasions.³¹ As such, the story of Skanderbeg was used to position Albania as the protector and preserver of Western identity, as a mechanism for sealing Albanian national identity as anti-Ottoman and authentically European.

Early twentieth-century attempts to modernise the nation further reveal connections between Albania's nationalism and whiteness. Towards the end of the nineteenth and into the early twentieth century, the New England region of the United States played host to a burgeoning community of Albanian nationalists, primarily those who had relocated from southern Albania. Groups such as the Pan-Albanian organisation *Vatra*, led by such figures as Bishop Fan Noli and Faik Konica, believed that they possessed a duty to reform the Albanian nation-state and develop a more cohesive national citizenry.³² The stances taken by *Vatra* contrasted with those of Albanian leaders in Albania, and provide insight into the ways that certain Albanian migrants in the West tried to align with Western whiteness.³³ Speaking on behalf of the national assembly in 1912, Ismail Qemali, the country's first Prime Minister, gave a speech about the newly developed nation-state. He argued that the path towards progress was a more diverse national identity that transcended religious distinctions. These statements were not eagerly received by Albanian leaders in the US.³⁴ Acting on behalf of *Vatra*, Faik Konica wrote a telegram urging the national assembly to take a different approach when choosing a path for Albania's future:

Vatra begs the Assembly to avoid accepting a Mohammedan Prince. Do not make the Albanian state like Khiva, Bokhara, Afghanistan, and Tunis. Our ideal is a European Albania like Norway, Denmark, Holland, or Belgium:

therefore, we strongly advise the selection of a decent European prince from a royal house, who will bring into Albania western culture and traditions.³⁵

Konica's statement depicts the ways that some Albanian leaders and thinkers wanted to distance themselves from the Ottoman Empire and to align Albania with understandings of Western culture and traditions, i.e., elements of whiteness. Their fears of Albania becoming like Afghanistan or being led by a Mohammedan Prince further highlight how Europeanness was configured in opposition to Muslimness.

One method used by these nationalists to further westernise Albania was through the importation of classical music and dance as a means of transforming the souls of Albanians. The Vatra band organised concerts and performances in southern Albania, in the city of Korça, to introduce European melodies as means to civilise the Albanian population. An editorialist from a local newspaper went as far as to implore Albanians to demonstrate a closer proximity to the 'civilized world', to show the world that Albania '[has] given up the Turkish airs'.³⁶ Vatra as an organisation 'signaled the general will of "the Albanians" to become modern', once again reiterating the notion of whiteness as arrival.³⁷ Researcher Nicholas Tochka is quick to acknowledge that there is no explicit evidence that these performances had a direct influence on the political decisions of the Great Powers, but this analysis provides examples of how Albanian nation-building projects and efforts to secure territory and autonomy may have been shaped by forms of whiteness.

At the same time that groups like Vatra were using music as a vehicle for introducing Western culture to Albania, Bishop Fan Noli used the arts, specifically theatre, as a means of explicitly engaging the subject of race. In 1916, Noli translated and directed Shakespeare's *Othello*, which was the first of his plays to be translated into and performed in Albanian.³⁸ Noli was among those Albanian nationalists who resided in the US and was influenced by racial discourse there. It is believed that he was motivated to translate *Othello* after witnessing anti-black racism in the US.³⁹ While Noli believed there was a connection between the experiences of black Americans and prejudice experienced by Albanians who had migrated to other countries, he was also prompted to translate and perform *Othello* to address racial discrimination in Albania. In Noli's version of the play, the character of Othello represents processes of othering; his alienation in Venice was intended to resemble the marginalisation and discrimination experienced by the Turkish, Muslim, as well as the Albanian other.⁴⁰ At the same time, Marinela Golemi argues that Noli desired to confront racial discrimination in Albania, as experienced by groups such as Roma and Egyptians. While the Albanian translation does not include explicit language naming Roma and Egyptians,

Noli's configuration of blackness is one that speaks to racial, ethnic, geographical, and religious alienation and marginalisation. I argue that Noli's version of *Othello* illustrates the complexities of peripheral racialisation, in that Albanians were positioned outside of European whiteness, a whiteness that was yearned for, as demonstrated by early nation-building projects. At the same time, we are able to see how Albanians were also at times positioned as white in contrast to those outside of white racial belonging. An examination of the country's socialist period further elucidates these paradoxes of the white periphery, as we consider how outwardly anti-colonial and anti-racist sentiments emerged alongside attempts to embed forms of European white belonging within national identity.

National narratives and racialisation in the socialist period

Between 1946 and 1991 Albania was under the control of the socialist Labour Party of Albania (Partia e Punës e Shqipërisë (PPSh)), led by Enver Hoxha from its inception until 1985. This period of Albania's history featured endeavours to solidify Albania's antique foundation within Europe in an effort to build a sociocultural and national coherence that had been unknown during the Ottoman and the interwar periods.⁴¹ Similarly to Albanian nationalists of the early twentieth century, Hoxha crafted a narrative in which Albanians had fought to preserve their identity for centuries, against the Ottomans, the Italians, and the Germans, evoking both anti-colonial and anti-Ottoman discourses.⁴² As a result of these occupations, there was a national obligation for Albanians to continually fight for and maintain their Albanianness under the party's guidance.⁴³ Such narratives lasted well into the 1980s and 1990s, as illustrated by primary school textbooks that framed such groups as Ottomans and Greeks as 'saboteurs of the Albanian national identity construction'.⁴⁴

Hoxha initially began his tenure by rejecting the past, but quickly realised that a particular version of history could be advantageous for party rule.⁴⁵ He emphasised Albanians' primordial presence in Europe, but, unlike the leaders of the early twentieth century, Hoxha depicted Albanians as the direct descendants of the Illyrians, an ancient Indo-European speaking group that inhabited the Balkan peninsula around 1000 BCE. This Illyrian–Albanian ethnogenesis was employed to lay claim to antiquity, as a means of asserting a belonging that framed Albanians as the original or first Europeans. The work of ethnologists during this era was used to illustrate that Albanians were a *pure* race of people who had fought and persisted to survive and preserve the Albanian race in the face of oppression.⁴⁶ And, similarly to the early twentieth century, the story of Skanderbeg was used to assert Albania's

role in safeguarding Europe from enemy expansion. Hoxha, like Zog, perpetuated the idea that he was a distant descendant of Skanderbeg, the only one capable of defending Albania.⁴⁷

Hoxha's efforts to civilise and modernise Albanians are further demonstrated by the internal relationship between northern and southern Albanians. Recent years have witnessed an increase in scholarship on the historical study of eugenics and racial nationalism in Southeast Europe.⁴⁸ At the moment, historical research has not uncovered a similar history in Albania, though there remains a need to more fully interrogate the subject as it pertains to Roma and Egyptian populations during the Communist era, since despite Hoxha's policies these groups have largely been considered culturally and biologically inferior to ethnic Albanians.⁴⁹ The historical record does however highlight how throughout Hoxha's reign, the party leader targeted northern Albanians, those often referred to as 'Gheg', for their supposed backwardness.⁵⁰ One of Hoxha's challenges included rectifying how Albanians were seen, not just through the Western gaze but the Soviet one too; rather, he wanted Albanians to be seen as 'civilised' Europeans as opposed to Muslims with connections to the Arab world.⁵¹ Hoxha's attempts to craft a new identity included efforts to bring the Ghegs of the North out of what was considered 'feudal isolation' through coercive labour that could cleanse Albania and develop within it a modern society; such endeavours included public ridicule of northerners, or mandating Catholic priests to clean toilets or don signs that they had 'sinned against the people'.⁵² In many ways, these forms of violence perpetuated by the regime 'reinforced a *Tosk* [southerner]⁵³ sense of power and later superiority which still permeates Albanian society today'. Such practices illustrate how the hankering for modernisation was bolstered by a desire for Albania to be seen as more European. Hoxha crafted an anti-capitalist Albania, accentuating a distance from the West. In fact, for many, the emergence of the PPSH, in the aftermath of fascist occupation, represented optimism for a liberated, anti-colonial, and anti-racist Albania. Yet tracing the ways that dominant national narratives and quests to liberate the country from backwardness provide an opportunity to consider whiteness as civilisational arrival. Though Hoxha clung tightly to notions of anti-coloniality and anti-racism, his quests to solidify Albanian purity, and the efforts to eradicate backwardness, may reveal a more complex and nuanced reality involving desires of a more European racial belonging.

Becoming white: performing whiteness in the contemporary moment

Peripheral whiteness has often been a shifting whiteness, one that captures the complexities of racial imaginaries that have excluded and included

Albanians within the borders of European racial belonging. Terms such as 'post-Ottoman' (which in Albania's case is often read as 'Muslim'), 'Balkan', and 'post-Communist' become cultural markers that further underscore the boundaries of authentic white European belonging. Returning to Blumi's framing of Albanians' anxious self-definition as European, contemporary aspirations for European belonging are shaped by intense desires to transcend these cultural markers determined by Albania's past; to shed baggage that precludes full inclusion.

Today, the figure of Skanderbeg could be viewed as a type of talisman for European belonging. He is a fixture in everyday life, ranging from monuments and squares in his honour to his face on the country's currency. Skanderbeg's narrative is used by politicians and leaders to reinstate Albania's position in Europe, and to sever its relationship with the 'alien' Ottoman Empire and Islam.⁵⁴ Skanderbeg demonstrates that Albania has always been European, and, for many Albanians, European Union membership would signify a more legitimate European belonging.⁵⁵ There are of course significant socioeconomic and political gains that would come from membership in the EU, particularly regarding travel, common trade policies, and standardised systems of laws; but membership in the EU carries meaning beyond these material benefits. In his inaugural speech as Prime Minister in 1992, after the first Albanian elections following state socialism, Sali Berisha proclaimed, 'The greatest dream of every Albanian is the integration of Albania into Europe.'⁵⁶ This type of hope and anticipation of EU membership is intimately tied to multiple processes of racialisation. Europe, to reference Rexhepi, is invoked as a 'post-national pan-European geopolitical entity tied by common history and geography and defined through race and religion'.⁵⁷ As the EU itself has fortified the boundaries of European belonging along racialised and immigrant lines,⁵⁸ Albanians have sought EU membership that could confer that same racial belonging. Peripheral whiteness, then, speaks to the ways that Albania is marginalised and that its status as European and racially white is made ambiguous. At the same time, this framework elucidates how this liminality is due to the shifting nature of whiteness itself. As the history of Albanian national movements illustrates, this European white racial belonging is both conditional (Europeanness must be authenticated) as well as necessary for Albanians to secure formal recognition of their country and their own survival.⁵⁹ This European whiteness, however, also necessitates the (re)production of an other, which whiteness is constructed against.⁶⁰

Many Albanians, indeed, believe that they are the *true* victims of racism, as illustrated by their outsider status within the Balkans and Europe as a whole. Racism is often framed as hate or as personal animus that a person holds in their heart. This is why many of my Albanian interlocutors adamantly express that Albanians are incapable of expressing racism, as illustrated

both by Albania's aforementioned marginalisation and what are often deemed sincere and widely shared practices of hospitality and welcoming of guests. This refusal of racism is fuelled by a deep longing to be included in white Europe, a longing that I argue intimately shapes local forms of racialisation and racism. One of the ways that we can locate the manifestation of whiteness in the contemporary Albanian context is by examining interrelations between Albanian, Romani, and Egyptian communities. Consider the following statements from my ethnographic fieldwork:

There was a time once when I was a younger girl. I used to live in a neighbourhood in Tirana where many of them stay, you know, the Jevgjit. One day while walking home I passed some of my neighbours who were seated outside. One person said, 'je bere si jevg' ('you have become like the jevgjit'), regarding my tanned skin from being outside. You know I went home and I cried and cried until my grandmother came into my room and said, 'do not cry, you are not dark, you are beautiful.'

We have spent all of our money now; we have become the jevgjit because they spend all of their money and they do not know how to save it.

Do not walk close to the house where those jevgjit live. You will not be able to breathe. You can smell them from one hundred meters away.

The term 'jevg' or 'jevgjit' in Albanian comes from 'evgjit', which is derived from 'Egjipt' ('Egypt'). In present-day Albania, this term is often used to refer to Balkan Egyptians, a group of people who are often considered Romani but in fact do not identify as Romani, and trace their heritage through Egypt rather than India.⁶¹ The well-known Albanian translator Pavli Qeshku translates 'evgjit' as a 'dark-skinned person' and 'jevg' as 'darkie'.⁶² There is little historical documentation about the first uses of this term, but as my previous research has shown, recent years have witnessed a discursive shift in which the term has increasingly become a racial marker.⁶³ It designates not just socioeconomic status but also a slur imbued with racist meaning. As illustrated with the ethnographic statements above, it is not uncommon to receive cautions about those considered 'jevg'; warnings about getting too dark from sun exposure, or about spending all of one's money and not saving it. The above statements elucidate how phenotypic markers, along with class inequality, the practice of waste collection, and a type of olfactory racism racialise Egyptian and Roma bodies in particular ways.⁶⁴

The formal socioracial categories of 'white' and 'black' are not used in official discourse from the Albanian government. The many common means of naming difference often include nation, language, religion, and ethnicity. Nevertheless, notions of whiteness and blackness do index forms of racial belonging in Albania. Particularly in central Albania, the language of 'dorë e bardhë' and 'dorë e zezë' is used to denote those who are of the 'white

hands' or 'white side' ('*dorë e bardhë*'), and those who are of the 'black hands' or 'black side' ('*dorë e zezë*'). Albanians are referred to as '*dorë e bardhë*' while Roma and Egyptians are considered '*dorë e zezë*'. Such racialisation practices provide insight into how race operates in Albania, and not simply as a means of phenotypic differentiation but as ways of marking social difference. These distinctions are linked to cultural practices, the boundaries of marriage, and the racialisation of space and housing. The Albanian terms '*zezë*' and '*bardhë*' directly translate as 'black' and 'white', respectively. It would however be simplistic to assume that they carry the same meaning of whiteness and blackness in a transatlantic context. Similar to many other lexicons, terms such as 'white' and 'black' are used to describe morality, luck, and superstition, with white being associated with goodness and purity, and black meaning accursed or stigmatised; blackness, in the Albanian language, often carries with it notions of misfortune or disgrace.⁶⁵ The presence of this linguistic white/black binary does not completely inform us about race, but as Stuart Hall articulated, race is a floating signifier, and these discursive practices do call attention to racial imaginaries in the Albanian context.⁶⁶ The language of '*dorë e bardhë*' and '*dorë e zezë*' illuminate racialised meanings of appearance and colour, and also what it means to be a black, stigmatised, or othered person. This is further illustrated by the Albanian term '*gabel*', a pejorative term used for Roma, which can be translated as 'stranger'. Terminology used to describe Roma and Egyptians draws attention to the ways that those racialised as 'black' are considered of another place, rendered to spaces of non-belonging.

White Albanians use the language of '*dorë e zezë*' ('black') to denote the actions of those who are othered and marginalised along residential, socio-economic, linguistic, and hygienic lines, ultimately those that do not demonstrate the cultural markers of whiteness. Roma and Egyptians in Tirana often employ the language and position of blackness as well, to distinguish themselves from white Albanians, and to draw attention to the everyday racism experienced by racially marginalised groups. These examples include the ways that blackness is articulated during collective protests or on social media. At times blackness is employed as a means to communicate a position of resistance, as Roma and Egyptians combat forms of racial injustice, such as was the case when Roma communities responded to an incident of police brutality in the Yzbërisht neighbourhood in Tirana in the spring of 2020.⁶⁷ Often though the language of blackness is most salient when interlocutors discuss what it means to be feel black, demonstrating the ways that Roma and Egyptians are racialised outside of whiteness, but also how anti-blackness shapes the social landscape in particular and localised ways. I examine these social relations in the context of whiteness, not as a means of equating the experiences of Roma and Egyptians with black

Americans or black-descended persons, but rather, to offer insight into local manifestations of the broader racial arrangements of Europe. I also point to how the Balkan region, despite claims to racelessness, is shaped by global racial structures. Such interpretation creates opportunities for analysing race, whiteness, and social differentiation from a relational rather than comparative perspective,⁶⁸ one in which we can move beyond questions of differentiation and examine the overlapping processes that shape parallel experiences of racialisation.

Concluding thoughts

Racial categories are not and never have been stable. Albania, and the Balkan region as a whole, is often considered a space of racelessness, yet my exploration of racialisation in Albania illustrates how racial hierarchies, and whiteness in particular, have historically shaped and continue to influence what it means to be Albanian. By historicising race in this region, scholars are able to chart forms of whiteness, particularly those that need to be nuanced given the ways that Central and Eastern Europe's sociopolitical and historical landscapes differ from the West's.

I offer the concept of peripheral whiteness as a tool for examining the shifting duality of whiteness in the context of Albania and Central and Eastern Europe. Albanians are racialised as external to European whiteness while locally performing whiteness against those racialised as black. As an analytic, peripheral whiteness attends to the complexities of Albania's history, highlighting how legacies of imperial rule, as well as the history of the country's nation-building projects and Communist past, have influenced understandings of whiteness and Albania's proximity to it. Peripheral whiteness offers an opening to critically interrogate how interwoven global processes of racial exclusion impact belonging and marginalisation in local contexts, thus highlighting the racial logics shaping livelihoods even in spaces thought to be raceless.

Notes

- 1 Chelsi West Ohueri, 'On Living and Moving with Zor: Exploring Racism, Embodiment, and Health in Albania', *Medical Anthropology*, 40:3 (2021), 241–53.
- 2 Isa Blumi, 'Battles of Nostalgic Proportion: The Transformations of Islam-as-Historical-Force in Western Balkan Reconstitutions of the Past', in Catharina Raudvere (ed.), *Nostalgia, Loss and Creativity in South-East Europe: Political*

- and *Cultural Representations of the Past* (Cham: Springer International, 2018), 40.
- 3 The term Egyptian here does not reference Egyptian nationals but rather a group that refers to itself as Balkan Egyptians. Often grouped under the umbrella category 'Roma', this social group asserts a separate, non-Romani identity. They do not speak Romani and trace their heritage through Egypt, rather than India. See Sevati Trubeta, 'Balkan Egyptians and Gypsy/Roma Discourse', *Nationalities Papers*, 33:1 (2005), 71–95.
 - 4 Philomena Essed and Sandra Trienekens, "'Who Wants to Feel White?': Race, Dutch Culture and Contested Identities", *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, 31:1 (2008), 52–72.
 - 5 Stephen Cornell and Douglas Hartmann, *Ethnicity and Race: Making Identities in a Changing World*, 2nd ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: Pine Forge Press, 2007); Jemima Pierre, *The Predicament of Blackness: Postcolonial Ghana and the Politics of Race* (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 2012); Nira Yural-Davis, 'Belonging and the Politics of Belonging', *Patterns of Prejudice*, 40:3 (2006), 197–214.
 - 6 Cedric J. Robinson, *Black Marxism: The Making of the Black Radical Tradition* (Chapel Hill, NC: University of North Carolina Press, 2000 [1983]).
 - 7 Jodi Melamed, 'Racial Capitalism', *Critical Ethnic Studies*, 1:1 (2015), 76–85.
 - 8 Gargi Bhattacharyya, *Rethinking Racial Capitalism: Questions of Reproduction and Survival* (London: Rowman and Littlefield, 2018).
 - 9 Kenton Card, *Geographies of Racial Capitalism with Ruth Wilson Gilmore: An Antipode Foundation Film* (New York: BFD Productions, 2020).
 - 10 David Theo Goldberg, 'Racial Europeanization', *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, 29:2 (2006), 331–64.
 - 11 Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Vintage, 1979); Maria Todorova, *Imagining the Balkans*, 2nd ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).
 - 12 Todorova, *Imagining the Balkans*.
 - 13 Dušan I. Bjelić, 'Abolition of a National Paradigm: The Case Against Benedict Anderson and Maria Todorova's Raceless Imaginaries', *Interventions*, 24:2 (2022), 239–62.
 - 14 Nikolay Zakharov and Ian Law, 'The Logics and Legacy of Soviet Racialization', in Nikolay Zakharov and Ian Law (eds), *Post-Soviet Racisms* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2017).
 - 15 Chelsi West Ohueri, 'Mapping Race and Belonging in the Margins of Europe: Albanian, Romani, and Egyptian Sentiments' (PhD dissertation, The University of Texas at Austin, 2016); see also West Ohueri, 'Zor'.
 - 16 Piro Rexhepi, *White Enclosures: Racial Capitalism and Coloniality Along the Balkan Route* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2023).
 - 17 Ivan Kalmar, *White But Not Quite: Central Europe's Illiberal Revolt* (Bristol: Bristol University Press, 2022).
 - 18 Ruth Frankenberg, *White Women, Race Matters: The Social Construction of Whiteness* (Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press, 1993).
 - 19 Gloria Wekker, *White Innocence: Paradoxes of Colonialism and Race* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2016).

- 20 Bjelić, 'Abolition of a National Paradigm'.
- 21 Neda Maghbouleh, *The Limits of Whiteness: Iranian Americans and the Everyday Politics of Race* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2017).
- 22 Edith Durham, *High Albania* (London: E. Arnold, 1909).
- 23 Božidar Jezernik, *Wild Europe: The Balkans in the Gaze of Western Travellers* (London: Saqi, 2004).
- 24 Carl von Linné, *Systema Naturae*, 10th ed. (Weinheim: J. Kramer, 1964 [1759]).
- 25 Jezernik, *Wild Europe*.
- 26 Here I return to both Wekker (*White Innocence*) and Frankenburg (*White Women, Race Matters*) regarding whiteness as often unmarked, unnamed, and invisibilised. In this case, whiteness is associated with the need to feel European and be recognised as such.
- 27 Noel Malcolm, 'Myths of Albanian National Identity: Some Key Elements, as Expressed in the Works of Albanian Writers in America in the Early Twentieth Century', in Stephanie Schwandner-Sievers and Bernd Jürgen Fischer (eds), *Albanian Identities: Myth and History* (Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press, 2002). It is possible that nationalist Albanian leaders in Western Europe and the United States were influenced by prevalent racial discourses in those regions.
- 28 Malcolm, 'Myths'.
- 29 On mythologies of warfare against the Ottomans, see also Baker, this volume.
- 30 Piro Misha, 'Invention of a Nationalism: Myth and Amnesia', in Schwandner-Sievers and Fischer (eds), *Albanian Identities*.
- 31 Iljazz Fishta and Michael Schmidt-Neke, 'Nationalism and National Myth: Skanderbeg and the Twentieth-Century Albanian Regimes', *European Legacy: Toward New Paradigms*, 2:1 (1997), 1–7.
- 32 Nicholas Tochka, 'To "Enlighten and Beautify": Western Music and the Modern Project of Personhood in Albania, c.1906–1924', *Ethnomusicology*, 59:3 (2015), 398–420.
- 33 Because processes of nation-building and identity formation involve various complexities, scholarly examinations must nuance analyses of nationalism. As such, this example of contrasting viewpoints does not necessarily illustrate a clear dichotomy between those Albanian nationalist leaders in New England with those based in Albania.
- 34 Tochka, "Enlighten and Beautify".
- 35 Federal Writers' Project, *The Albanian Struggle in the Old World and New* (Boston, MA: The Writer, 1939). See also Tochka, "Enlighten and Beautify".
- 36 Tochka, "Enlighten and Beautify".
- 37 Ibid.
- 38 Marinela Golemi, 'Othello in the Balkans: Performing Race Rhetoric on the Albanian Stage', *Multicultural Shakespeare: Translation, Appropriation and Performance*, 22:37 (2020), 125–38.
- 39 Over the years, Othello's racial identity has been one of the play's key analytical themes. As Patrick C. Hogan has noted, Othello is a character who has experienced racism and is the victim of racial despair (see Patrick C. Hogan, "Othello", Racism, and Despair', *CLA Journal*, 41:4 (1998), 431–51). Such

- ideas have been debated by numerous scholars, but according to Golemi it was this interpretation of Othello's character which prompted Noli to translate the play into Albanian.
- 40 Golemi, 'Othello in the Balkans'.
 - 41 Isa Blumi, 'The Commodification of Otherness and the Ethnic Unit in the Balkans: How to Think About Albanians', *East European Politics and Society*, 12:3 (1998), 527–69. See also Michael Galaty, *Memory and Nation Building: From Ancient Times to the Islamic State* (Lanham, MD: Rowman and Littlefield, 2018).
 - 42 Genta Nishku, 'The Wretched on the Walls: A Fanonian Reading of a Revolutionary Albanian Orphanage', *Feminist Critique*, 3 (2020), 39–63.
 - 43 Galaty, *Memory*; Elidor Mëhilli, *From Stalin to Mao: Albania and the Socialist World* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2017).
 - 44 Ridvan Peshkopia and Konstantinos Giakoumis, 'Nationalistic Education and its Colourful Role in Intergroup Prejudice Reduction: Lessons from Albania', *Journal of Southeast European and Black Sea Studies*, 21:3 (2021), 457–80.
 - 45 Misha, 'Invention'.
 - 46 Armanda Hysa, 'Ethnography in Communist Albania: Nationalist Discourse and Relations with History', in Katarina Keber and Luka Vidmar (eds), *Historični seminar 8* (Ljubljana: Založba ZRC, 2010).
 - 47 Blumi, 'Battles'.
 - 48 Marius Turda and Paul J. Weindling (eds), *Blood and Homeland: Eugenics and Racial Nationalism in Central and Southeast Europe, 1900–1940* (Budapest: CEU Press, 2007); Marius Turda, *Modernism and Eugenics* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2010); Maria Bucur, 'Eugenics in Eastern Europe, 1870s–1945', in Alison Bashford and Philippa Levine (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of the History of Eugenics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010).
 - 49 See my forthcoming work, *Albania in Red, Black, and White* (manuscript in progress).
 - 50 Isa Blumi. 'The Politics of Culture and Power: The Roots of Hoxha's Postwar State', *East European Quarterly*, 31:3 (1997), 379–98, 379.
 - 51 Mëhilli, *Stalin to Mao*.
 - 52 Blumi, 'Politics'.
 - 53 Deriving from the Ottoman term 'Toskalik', 'Tosk' is a term that refers to one of Albania's two major dialectal and cultural subgroups. The other major group, Gheg Albanians, reside in northern Albania, north of the Shkumbin river, and primarily speak the Gheg dialect of Albanian. It is important to note that many of the Party's leaders were Tosk and that Enver Hoxha emerged from the southern city of Gjirokastër. See Blumi, 'Politics', for more on the distinctions between Gheg and Tosk and how these manifested during state socialism.
 - 54 Blumi, 'Battles'.
 - 55 Nicola Nixon, 'Always Already European: The Figure of Skënderbeg in Contemporary Albanian Nationalism', *National Identities*, 12:1 (2010), 1–20; Merje Kuus, 'Europe's Eastern Expansion and the Reinscription of Otherness in East-Central Europe', *Progress in Human Geography*, 28:4 (2004), 472–89.

- 56 Blendi Kajsio, *Albanian Democratization Between Europeanization and Neo-liberalism* (Tirana: Albanian Institute for International Studies, 2011).
- 57 Rexhepi, *White Enclosures*, 5.
- 58 Garner, Steve. 'The European Union and the Racialization of Immigration, 1985–2006', *Race/Ethnicity: Multidisciplinary Global Contexts*, 1:1 (2007), 61–87.
- 59 Rexhepi, *White Enclosures*.
- 60 Frankenberg, *White Women*; Essed and Trienekens, "Who Wants to Feel White?".
- 61 In my previous scholarship I have provided longer analyses of Romani and Egyptian socioracial identities in Albania (West Ohueri, 'Mapping Race'), but for this particular chapter I focus less on these distinctions and instead highlight how these ethnographic examples illustrate the ways that racialisation and forms of whiteness operate. It is also important to note that while there are distinctions between Roma and Egyptians in Albania, both groups are often racialised collectively.
- 62 Pavli Qesku, *Fjalor Shqip-Anglisht*, ed. Fatmir Xhaferi (Tirana: Botime EDFa, 2004).
- 63 See West Ohueri, 'Mapping Race'; West Ohueri, 'Zor'.
- 64 Andrew Kettler, *The Smell of Slavery: Olfactory Racism and the Atlantic World* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020).
- 65 Golemi, 'Othello in the Balkans'.
- 66 See Stuart Hall and Sut Jhally, *Race the Floating Signifier: Stuart Hall in Lecture* (Northampton, MA: Media Education Foundation, 2002).
- 67 Gjergj Erebara, 'Organizatat dënojnë dhunën e policisë bashkiake ndaj ricikluesit', *Reporter.al*, 26 May 2020, www.reporter.al/organizatat-denojne-dhunen-e-polices-bashkiake-ndaj-ricikluesit/ (accessed 5 December 2022).
- 68 João Helion Costa Vargas, *The Denial of Antiracism: Multiracial Redemption and Black Suffering* (Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press, 2018).